without him or the accompanying Chinese delegation.

What we may conclude from the somewhat confused accounts contained in Ibn Battuta's diaries is that during the Yuan dynasty (1227–1368 CE) in China, some contacts between the two countries still continued. There may have been a trade and pilgrimage route via India's North East, as we had seen during the early years of the first millennium also (see Chapter 5). It is possible that the Chinese delegation Ibn Battuta refers to may have been acting on behalf of the Tibetans, who may have been visiting some temple or monastery associated with Tibetan Buddhism in upper Assam, then known as Kamrupa.

We also have evidence that during the fourteenth century there was a flourishing maritime trade between the ports of Malabar and the southern coast of China, in particular Guangzhou. Chinese junks, already the largest known vessels of the time, sailed to these ports regularly, carrying silk and porcelain and going back with cargoes of fine cotton, pepper and a variety of spices. It appears that these large vessels were already being made in China before the voyages of the Chinese admiral Zheng He later in the fifteenth century. These enormous sailing ships were not necessarily made only for his expeditions. Even though the Central Asian land route between the two countries was interrupted from the beginning of the second millennium, trade and religious contacts continued by the maritime route and perhaps even by land routes through India's North East, linking it with southern China via Yunnan province and through Tibet.

Huen Tsang (Xuan Zang), Si-Yu-Ki; Buddhist Records of the Western World, translated by Samuel Beal, 1884, reprint by Oriental Books Reprint Corporation, 1968.

Zhang Yuan, 'Hars.a and China: The Six Diplomatic Missions in the Early 7th Century', The Delhi University Journal of the Humanities & the Social Sciences, vol. 2, 2015, pp. 1–24.

Sun Shao and Chen Zhibin, Snows of the Himalaya mountains: The True Record of the China-India War, Bei Yue Wenyi Chubanshe, 1991.

Roderick MacFarquhar, The Origins of the Cultural Revolution, vol. 3, Columbia University Press, 1997, Chapter 12.